



A RESIDENT at a memorial Sunday near where federal agents shot Alex Pretti a day earlier in Minneapolis.

Trump’s playbook falters in response to Minnesota killing

The Trump administration has blamed the death of an American citizen at the hands of immigration agents in Minnesota on the victim within hours of their killing for the second time this month, calling Alex Jeffrey Pretti an “assassin” and “domestic terrorist” without opening an independent investigation.

The crisis response from President Trump’s top Homeland Security officials followed a familiar playbook from an administration eager to project grit and resolve, particularly on immigration, in the face of inconvenient facts. Despite their efforts, damage from the incident continued to reverberate Sunday, creating political jeopardy for the president.

After another protester is slain by federal agents, administration’s blunt denial of evidence poses political peril

By Michael Wilner

Videos that emerged of Pretti’s killing enraged the public. Government lines justifying the use of lethal force prompted blowback among staunch Republican supporters and conservative groups. Negotiations in Congress to thwart another shutdown were upended over Immigration and Customs Enforcement funding. And a Trump-appointed judge blocked the administration from attempting to destroy evidence in the case, lending weight to fears of a cover-up.

It is new terrain for Trump, whose handling of immigration had been a rare bright spot in polling of his job performance throughout his first year back in office. [See Response, A5]

After shooting, ‘people have had enough’

In the courts and on the streets, a demand for justice over latest death in Minnesota.

By IAN JAMES

Public outrage continued to grow in Minnesota and across the country Sunday after federal immigration agents shot and killed a man.

A federal judge issued an order blocking the Trump administration from “destroying or altering evidence” related to the shooting of 37-year-old Alex Pretti in Minneapolis on Saturday.

Videos showed that federal agents who were wrestling Pretti to the ground took a handgun from him moments before firing multiple times. The images showed Pretti, who had a permit to carry a gun, did not brandish the weapon before the shooting. He was holding up a phone when the agents approached him.

“The videos speak for themselves,” Minneapolis Police Chief Brian O’Hara told CBS News’ “Face the Nation With Margaret Brennan” on Sunday. “It appears that he was present, exercising his 1st Amendment rights to record law enforcement activity and also exercising his 2nd Amendment rights to lawfully be armed in a public space in the city. So I think very obviously, there are serious questions that are being raised.”

The killing of Pretti has sparked demonstrations and vigils in Minneapolis

and other cities across the country, including Los Angeles. Hundreds of demonstrators protested peacefully in downtown L.A. on Saturday, chanting, “Abolish ICE!” More demonstrations were held Sunday.

Pretti, an intensive care unit nurse at the Minneapolis VA Medical Center, was shot just over a mile from where an Immigration and Customs Enforcement officer killed 37-year-old Renee Nicole Good on Jan. 7, sparking widespread protests.

“People have had enough. This is the third shooting now in less than three weeks,” O’Hara said, noting the two fatal shootings and another that left a man injured.

O’Hara told CNN that the chaotic scene in the videos as officers descended on Pretti “looks very untrained” and is “absolutely not how we train law enforcement in Minnesota.”

Federal officials said agents fired defensively Saturday morning when Pretti stepped into a confrontation between an immigration officer and a woman on the street.

Videos recorded by bystanders show Pretti stepping in and holding a phone after an immigration officer shoved a woman. The officer shoves Pretti in his chest, and pepper-sprays him and the woman. Soon, at least seven officers are forcing Pretti to the ground, and several officers try to bring his arms behind his back as he struggles against them. Within moments, the first [See Outrage, A5]

Fight rages over beloved eatery

Longtime owner of landmark Saugus Cafe alleges a takeover scam in a lawsuit.

By SUHAUNA HUSSAIN

After the longest-operating cafe in L.A. County announced in late December that it would shut down after 139 years, customers of the Original Saugus Cafe began buying up its branded hats, T-shirts, mugs and other merchandise.

When the merch sold out, some took to filching from the tables: glassware, salt and pepper shakers, and even utensils.

To Jessie Mercado, 31, and her father, Alfredo — who has owned the beloved cafe in Santa Clarita for 30 years — it was amusing and sweet that many held the establishment so close to their hearts that they wanted to take pieces of it home with them.

But a property manager who took over handling their lease in recent months saw it differently. He left an angry voicemail for Jessie Mercado’s 59-year-old father, reviewed by The Times, telling him to “get the godd— s— back” or he would sue.

Customers of the Original Saugus Cafe didn’t have long to mourn the loss of the landmark. The restaurant, which closed on Jan. 4, has already reopened under new management. Meanwhile, behind the scenes, a dispute over the cafe’s ownership has boiled over into a lawsuit as the Mercados insist that they were pushed out. [See Saugus, A6]

The rise, fall and rise of Brett Ratner



BRETT RATNER has become a part of Melania Trump’s trusted inner circle.

Years after #MeToo banishment, director returns with a film about the first lady.

By STACY PERMAN

In late 2024, shortly after her husband, Donald Trump, was reelected as the 47th president of the United States, Melania Trump saw an opportunity: a documentary centered on her life.

The film, a follow-up to her eponymous memoir, would offer a window into the first lady’s private, sphinx-like world, in contrast to that of her bombastic, spotlight-seeking husband.

To direct the film, a fly-on-the-wall chronicle of the 20 days leading up to the inauguration, [See Ratner, A9]

‘Water bankruptcy’: U.N. warns of global long-term depletion

By IAN JAMES

Dozens of the world’s major rivers are so heavily tapped, they often run dry before reaching the sea. More than half of all large lakes are shrinking, and most of the world’s major underground sources are declining irreversibly as agricultural pumping drains water that took centuries or even thousands of years to accumulate.

In a report last week, United Nations scientists warned that the world has entered a new era of “global water bankruptcy” — a term that starkly underlines the urgency of efforts needed to protect what remains.

“For too long, we have been living beyond our hydrological means,” said lead author Kaveh Madani, director of the U.N. University’s Institute for Water, Environment and Health.

Drawing on extensive research, the report says more and more regions of the world are in effect overspending from all their water accounts, and their reserves are dropping. The term “water crisis” is often used locally and globally, but the scientists said that denotes a temporary emergency from which a region can recover, whereas many parts of the world are depleting water beyond safe limits and are now bankrupt or approaching bankruptcy.

Many rivers, lakes, aquifers and wetlands have been pushed past “tipping points” and cannot bounce back, the report says.

“Millions of farmers are trying to grow more food [See Water, A8]



AMY HARRIS Invision/Associated Press

A LEGACY OF DIGNITY

Dolly Parton’s dedication and decency stand out to Martha Ackmann, author of a new book on the singer-philanthropist. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

Congressman attacked at party

Florida Rep. Maxwell Frost says a man yelled racist remarks before the assault at Sundance festival. **NATION, A6**

Weather

Clouds dissipate. L.A. Basin: 75/50. **B6**

Palisades High is deemed safe

L.A. Unified says the campus was cleaned, but some express worries. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

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Is state’s proposed billionaire tax smart policy?

By KEVIN RECTOR

In the rolling debate over California’s proposed billionaire tax, supporters and critics agree that such policies haven’t always worked in the past. But the lessons they’ve drawn from that history are wildly different.

The Billionaire Tax Act, which backers are pushing to get on the November ballot, would charge California’s 200-plus billionaires a one-time, 5% tax on their net worth in order to backfill billions of dollars in Republican-led cuts to federal healthcare funding for middle-class and low-income residents.

Critics of the proposal have argued that past failures of similar wealth taxes in Europe prove they don’t work and can cause more harm than good, including by driving the ultra-rich out. Among those critics is San José Mayor Matt Mahan, a tech-friendly Democrat who is contemplating a run for governor.

“Over the last 30 years, we’ve seen a dozen European countries pursue national-level wealth taxes,” Mahan said. “Nine of them have rolled them back. A majority have seen a decline in overall revenue. It’s actually shrunk the tax base, not increased it, and it’s because it creates a perverse incentive and drives capital flight.”

Backers of the measure acknowledge such failures but say that they learned from them and that California’s proposal is stronger as a result.

Brian Galle, a UC Berkeley tax law professor and one of four academic experts who drafted the measure, [See Taxes, A8]